

The Secret

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CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 4 — THE SECRET

OPENING

Lights rise on a marketplace-adjacent work area.

SHIRA, TALIA, ADINA and DAFNA are occupied with ordinary tasks.

Possible activity

folding fabric;

sorting jewelry;

sewing;

arranging clothing;

preparing baskets;

threading beads;

organizing goods.

The scene should initially feel completely normal.

MARY enters.

She is trying to appear normal.

She is not succeeding.

Shira sees her first.

DAFNA

Mary!

Mary jumps. A small release of tension.

SHIRA, TALIA, ADINA, and DAFNA enter, carrying ordinary life with them: fabric, baskets, beads, clothing, market goods, or another established task from the Living Village.

ADINA

There you are.

TALIA

We have been looking everywhere.

DAFNA

Not everywhere.

TALIA

Enough places to justify saying everywhere.

Shira sees Mary clearly.

SHIRA

...Mary?

MARY

I'm here.

ADINA

We can see that.

DAFNA

Barely.

MARY

I'm fine.

Shira watches her. Mary tries to move with them.

ADINA

Good. Then come on.

MARY

Yes.

Mary does not move.

ADINA

Mary.

MARY

I'm coming.

She still does not move.

TALIA

You said that without moving any part of your body.

DAFNA

Maybe she's practicing.

Mary tries to smile. Shira does not.

SHIRA

What happened?

MARY

Nothing.

Shira waits.

SHIRA

Mary.

Mary looks at the four women who have known her for years.

MARY

I need to tell you something.

THEY THINK THEY KNOW THE SECRET

The four women immediately become attentive in four different ways: Adina prepares to act, Talia studies Mary, Dafna anticipates a story, Shira watches Mary's face.

DAFNA

Joseph moved the wedding.

MARY

No.

TALIA

You and Joseph argued.

MARY

No.

DAFNA

Joseph said something foolish.

MARY

No.

TALIA

That remains statistically possible.

MARY

Talia.

ADINA

Is something wrong with the house?

MARY

No.

DAFNA

You're leaving Nazareth.

MARY

No.

Beat.

DAFNA

You kissed him.

Mary stares at her.

DAFNA

That was not a no.

SHIRA

Dafna.

DAFNA

OK! I'm Done.

Beat.

DAFNA

For now.

Mary almost smiles. Then Shira sees her face again. The humor disappears for Shira first.

SHIRA

Mary. What happened?

Mary takes a breath.

MARY

Something happened.

THE REVELATION

TALIA

What kind of something?

MARY

I don't know how to explain it.

TALIA

Start with what happened.

Mary looks at Talia.

MARY

That's the problem.

Silence.

MARY

Last night... I was alone.

She stops.

SHIRA

Take your time.

MARY

I don't think more time is going to make it sound any better.

DAFNA

That's not comforting.

Shira gives Dafna a look.

DAFNA

Sorry.

MARY

Someone came to me.

TALIA

Who?

MARY

A messenger.

ADINA

From whom?

Mary looks at them.

MARY

God.

Silence. No music. Let the word sit.

TALIA

A messenger from God.

MARY

Yes.

ADINA

Mary...

MARY

His name was Gabriel.

DAFNA

Gabriel WHO?

SHIRA

The Angel!..shhh...

MARY

He told me I had been chosen.

TALIA

Chosen for what?

Mary cannot soften it.

MARY

I'm going to have a child.

Silence.

DAFNA

Someday?

MARY

No.

Beat.

MARY

Now.

The four women absorb it.

ADINA

Does Joseph know?

MARY

No.

The room changes.

SHIRA

How?

Mary looks at her.

MARY

That's the part you're not going to believe.

MARY

Gabriel told me the child comes from God.

THE FIRST TEST OF THE TRUTH

Silence. Mary looks at the faces of four people who know her. Nobody has a prepared response.

TALIA

Mary...

MARY

I know.

TALIA

Listen to what you're asking us to believe.

MARY

I know.

TALIA

I'm not calling you a liar.

MARY

Then what are you saying?

TALIA

I'm saying I don't know how both things can be true.

Mary takes that in. It is painfully close to the questions she herself asked Gabriel.

MARY

Neither did I.

TALIA

What?

MARY

I asked him how.

Beat.

MARY

I asked why me. I asked what happens now.

TALIA

And?

MARY

I didn't get all the answers either.

TALIA

Then help me understand what you did get.

MARY

I can't. Not completely.

Talia wants another question. Mary sees it.

MARY

I know how it sounds.

TALIA

Then you understand why—

MARY

Yes!

The volume surprises everyone, including Mary.

MARY

Yes.

She steadies herself.

MARY

I don't understand exactly why.

Beat.

MARY

But, I still know what happened to me.

FOUR FRIENDS, FOUR RESPONSES

ADINA

When are you telling Joseph?

MARY

Today.

ADINA

Before anyone else knows.

MARY

Yes.

ADINA

Good.

SHIRA

Adina.

ADINA

I'm trying to help.

SHIRA

I know.

Dafna has been unusually quiet.

MARY

Dafna?

DAFNA

I'm trying very hard not to say the wrong thing.

A tiny breath of warmth.

MARY

How is that going?

DAFNA

Poorly.

Then Dafna becomes sincere.

DAFNA

I believe you.

Everyone looks at her.

DAFNA

I don't understand it.

Beat.

DAFNA

But I believe you. I'm still working on the rest.

Mary gives the smallest laugh through the tension.

Shira steps nearer, but does not crowd Mary.

SHIRA

Are you afraid?

MARY

Yes.

SHIRA

Then I'm staying.

Mary looks at her.

SHIRA

I can't promise you Joseph will understand.

Beat.

SHIRA

And I can't promise you he won't be hurt.

Beat.

SHIRA

But you're not walking to him alone.

THE SECRET LEAVES THE CIRCLE

The women continue speaking. Ordinary Nazareth traffic quietly resumes behind or around them. This is not a spy scene. People are simply living their lives.

ADINA

Who else knows?

MARY

No one.

ADINA

Your family?

MARY

No.

TALIA

Anyone could have seen Gabriel come in.

MARY

I don't know.

ADINA

And Joseph doesn't know.

MARY

No.

A PASSING VILLAGER or MERCHANT crosses on a real errand. They hear only: 'Joseph doesn't know.' They do not stop.

TALIA

And you're saying the child comes from God.

MARY

Yes.

The passing villager hears only a fragment: 'the child' and perhaps 'God.' They keep moving. No suspicious glance. No ominous cue.

DAFNA

Oh, Mary.

TALIA

What are you going to tell him?

MARY

The truth.

TALIA

And if he doesn't believe it?

That lands.

MARY

Then I don't know what happens next.

Shira holds Mary's gaze.

SHIRA

You don't have to know how it ends tonight.

MARY

Apparently, nobody does.

A small, human release.

SHIRA

Then do the next thing.

MARY

Joseph.

SHIRA

Joseph.

MARY CHOOSES THE NEXT STEP

ADINA

Do you want us with you?

Mary considers.

MARY

Not when I tell him.

She looks at Shira.

MARY

But... walk with me?

SHIRA

You don't even have to ask.

If physical contact is already consented and staged, Shira offers a hand. Mary chooses to take it.

They begin to move.

TALIA

Mary.

Mary turns.

TALIA

I still don't understand it.

Mary nods.

TALIA

But I don't have to understand everything tonight.

Beat.

TALIA

I do know you.

Mary absorbs that.

ADINA

And I'm with you.

DAFNA

Obviously.

TALIA

Nothing about you is obvious.

DAFNA

My loyalty is.

That lands more deeply than Dafna intended.

MARY

Thank you.

Mary and Shira start away.

TALIA

What exactly are you going to say?

Mary stops. For once, she has no answer.

Shira answers quietly.

SHIRA

Start with what you know.

Mary looks at Shira.

SHIRA

Start with the truth.

MARY

The truth.

Beat.

MARY

All right.

Mary and Shira exit toward Joseph. Adina, Talia, and Dafna watch them go.

THE AUDIENCE KNOWS SOMETHING MARY DOESN'T

Do not follow Mary.

The PASSING VILLAGER reappears elsewhere in the living marketplace and crosses paths with another villager. Keep it small enough that Mary and her friends do not see or hear it.

GOSSIPER 4

Mary?

The first villager does not pretend to know the whole story.

GOSSIPER 2

That's what I heard.

They move on.

The line should echo the harmless information-transmission comedy of Scene 1, but the meaning has changed.

TRANSITION INTO SCENE 5

One beat of silence.

BANG!

A hammer strikes wood.

BANG!

Another.

BANG-BANG!

A completely different energy takes over. Lights shift sharply to Joseph's world.

JOSEPH is working, laughing, and completely unaware. LEVI, MALACHI, CALEB and EZRA are with him. The Scene 5 carpentry rhythm begins to emerge.

Mary is walking toward the most frightening conversation of her life.

Joseph is having a wonderful day.

He is building the future the audience now knows is about to be tested.

END SCENE 4.

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